# Co-op and Career Services

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## Co-operative Training Program

The Co-op training program bridges the intense learning experience of university and the practical, results-oriented, highly competitive professional world. The program is designed to allow the student to test and apply knowledge, skills, and competencies acquired in classrooms and labs, and to develop a clear perspective on real-world expectations and a sharper focus on career choices. It allows employers and educators to collaborate in mentoring the prospective workforce to become productive and responsible citizens. The hope is that the student, after completing the Co-op experience, will develop a clear purpose, become more engaged during the final year of studies, and adopt a pragmatic perspective on their role in a changing world.

### Significance

While the Co-op work experience mutually benefits the student, the university, and the employer, it will help the student in:

- Clarifying career goals;
- Understanding of the workplace demands and constraints;
- Pursuing continuous learning and self-improvement undertakings;
- Cultivating self-reliance and self-confidence;
- Refining time management, interpersonal, and communication skills;
- Building contacts with potential employers;
- Acquiring marketable skills that improve employability prospects;
- Experiencing practical aspects of the field of study.

### General Policy

1. The logistical aspects of the Co-op program shall be managed by the Co-op Coordinator associated with the Office of Academic Affairs.
2. Training opportunities shall be approved and thereafter managed by the Co-op Coordinator in collaboration with the academic advisor.
3. Students must meet the eligibility criteria outlined in this policy to participate in the Co-op program.
4. Students may arrange for a training opportunity on their own, or the Co-op and Career Services Assistant will assist the student in finding a suitable training venue.
5. A student may opt to complete the Co-op training at a reputable institution abroad, subject to pertinent approvals.

6. Each trainee shall be assigned a Co-op academic advisor to follow up on the trainee's work progress throughout the Co-op period and assess the overall training experience afterward.
7. A student must commit to completing the training at the mutually agreed-upon company.
8. Students may register for one course during the Co-op period if it is the only course needed to graduate and the employer approves the timing in writing.
9. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant completes the Co-op training offers in consultation with the Co-op work HR/supervisor, considering the employer's needs, the student's interest and eligibility, and the date of the student's application.
10. The trainee shall work for the employer for a period equivalent to eight weeks, 8 hours per day, on mutually agreeable tasks related to the trainee's field of study.
11. Trainees must conform to the employer's work rules and standards and execute their tasks professionally and ethically.
12. The student shall directly report to and coordinate with the Co-op work supervisor on all tasks and activities.
13. The Co-op work supervisor cannot be a direct relative of the trainee;
14. The Trainee shall keep a daily record of tasks performed and lessons learned;
15. The trainee and the Co-op work supervisor shall submit the training assessment forms to the Co-op academic advisor one week after completing the training.
16. The trainee shall submit to the Co-op academic advisor the daily tasks log, a report, a poster, and a PowerPoint presentation immediately after completing the Co-op work.
17. The trainee must deliver a presentation about the training experience when requested as part of the Co-op Inspiration Seminar.
18. Students can only withdraw from the Co-op course upon approval from the Co-op academic advisor and the Co-op and Career Services Assistant.
19. Failing to comply with the Co-op rules and the employer's work standards will result in a failing grade.
20. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant and the Co-op academic advisor are always available to support the student in attaining a rewarding Co-op experience.
21. The Chairperson of the academic department is responsible for implementing the provisions in this policy related to the academic advisor and student responsibilities.

## Requirements

### Duration and Timing

The Co-op program runs for at least eight weeks, 8 hours per day, and is normally completed during the summer term of the third year of studies. Students engage in practical training under the mentorship of professionals in areas related to their field of interest.

### Eligibility Criteria

A Bachelor's student is eligible to sign up for the Co-op program if the following eligibility criteria are met:

1. Completing ENGL 217 and the requisite number of credits with a GPA of at least 70.
2. Enrolling at the university during the training period.
3. Completing all college pre-training course requirements as stipulated below.

| College | Credits | Prerequisite |
|---|---|---|
| Engineering | 1 | • Passes ENGL 217<br>• Senior Standing<br>• Has a CGPA of 70 or higher |
| Business Administration | 1 | • Passes ENGL 217<br>• Senior Standing<br>• Has a CGPA of 70 or higher |
| Arts and Sciences | 1-3 | • Passes ENGL 217<br>• Senior Standing<br>• Has a CGPA of 70 or higher |

## Course Preparations

In preparation for the Co-op training, students must attend the Co-op Policies and Procedures, CV Writing, and Interview Skills seminars. The Co-op Policies and Procedures seminar introduces the Co-op Training Program for all Co-op Students and outlines the required policies and procedures. The CV Writing seminar helps students hone their CV writing skills.

Students must also attend an Interview Skills seminar covering how to prepare for an interview, what to expect, and how to make a good impression.

## Co-op Assignment

The Co-op and Career Services Assistant maintains a database of prospective employers and attempts to match the employers' needs with the students' fields of study and personal preferences. However, a student may secure a training venue through personal communications and agree with the employer on the conditions of employment. In this case, students in the early spring semester must provide the Co-op and Career Services Assistant with the contact information for the prospective employer and work supervisor, as well as the conditions of employment, for approval. Once approved, the Co-op and Career Services Assistant follows up with the prospective employer in accordance with the established Co-op procedures. Applicable rules: the organization is reputable and not owned by the student's parent; a student may not be supervised by a family member or assigned to a department where a family member works. Required Information for Co-op requests outside the offerings of the Co-op and Career Services Assistant: Organization name, company profile (website), Job description/training plan, supervisor name, contact person, and contact details.

## Procedures

1. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant creates a co-op Moodle course for eligible students in each college.
2. The student should read, understand, and complete the Co-op Code of Conduct before the beginning of the Co-op period.
3. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant prepares a database of prospective employers, posts job opportunities and application deadlines, and communicates them to students via email and Moodle.
4. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant prepares a list of eligible students with the help of the Registrar's Office (RO).
5. Students may suggest an employer not on the posted list as long as they get tentative approval from the employer, the College academic advisor, and the Co-op and Career Services Assistant.
6. A trainee seeking a training opportunity abroad must complete the ***Training Abroad Application Form*** (Co-op-12) and submit it to the Co-op and Career Services Assistant for further consideration.
7. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant communicates with prospective employers and provides them with necessary information about the potential trainees' profiles.
8. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant invites eligible students to attend the Co-op orientation seminar in early spring to explain co-op policies and procedures.
9. Each eligible student completes the ***Co-op Application Form*** (Co-op-3), indicating three preferred Co-op venues ranked in order of priority, and submits a CV (soft copy) within the assigned deadlines;
10. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant and academic units shall attempt to match students' aspirations and fields of study with the employer's needs within two weeks of the submitted applications. If multiple trainees compete for a specific training opportunity, students who apply first and meet the eligibility criteria shall be prioritized.
11. The Co-op assignments and all related information are posted by the Co-op and Career Services Assistant on the Co-op Moodle course page and via email.
12. Each academic unit informs the students of the Co-op assignment via email. The student must know that the employer may contact them for an interview before committing to the assignment.
13. The academic advisor bears the responsibility to make at least one field visit and complete the visit assessment form; continuously follow up with the trainee and the work supervisor during the training period; collect the trainee's performance assessment forms from the trainee and the work supervisor; guides the student in preparing the training report, poster and presentation and assess the submitted material; and submits a final report to the Co-op and Career Services Assistant.

## Trainee's Responsibilities

Students must fulfill the following responsibilities by the indicated dates to guarantee Co-op placement and avoid any delay toward graduation.

1. Maintain contact with the Co-op and Career Services Assistant to inquire about the

application status before training begins and update the office immediately on the work conditions during the training period.
2. Attend the orientation workshop and get familiar with the Co-op rules and regulations;
3. Set training goals in collaboration with the work supervisor and academic advisor, and drive to achieve them;
4. Perform all tasks to the highest ethical and professional expectations;
5. Complete all necessary documents by the established deadlines. Students must submit in the last week of the Co-op period the following:
    a) Trainee's Assessment of Training Form
    b) Training Tasks log
    c) A formal report
    d) A poster
    e) A PowerPoint presentation
6. Complete all necessary documents by the established deadlines;
7. Comply with the employer's work rules, policies, and standards;
8. Closely coordinate with the work supervisor to execute tasks as planned;
9. Discuss concerns and work-related inquiries with the academic advisor;
10. Complete and submit the Trainee's Assessment of Training Form;
11. Submit a formal report, a daily log of tasks, a poster, and a presentation directly after completing the training period using appropriate forms;
12. Participate in the Co-op poster exhibition;
13. Complete the entire training period agreed to.

### Assessment

Based on the employer's evaluation, academic advisors' assessment, and the submitted formal report, daily log of tasks, poster, and presentation, the Co-op academic advisor will assign the student a Pass with Honors "PH," Pass "P," or Fail "F" grade. "PH" is reserved for a trainee who receives an outstanding performance evaluation from the work supervisor and the co-op academic advisor. A grade of "F" is given to a trainee who receives an unsatisfactory evaluation by the work supervisor and the Co-op academic advisor. In this case, the trainee must repeat the whole Co-op experience.

## Career Services

### Rationale

The Co-op and Career Services Assistant relays information about available job vacancies to RHU alumni to assist them with the employment process, career changes and transitions, and networking opportunities.

### Policy

1. Communicate and build a database of prospective employers

2. Compile and announce job vacancies to students and alumni.
3. Conduct seminars to help students prepare CVs, interview skills, etc.
4. Maintain a CV data bank and send CVs to concerned employers.
5. Organize an annual job fair.
6. Create a database of job market needs to help in curricular planning and selection of Summative Learning projects.

## Procedure

1. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant receives information on available job vacancies from companies in and outside Lebanon.
2. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant posts the job vacancies with a brief description of the job requirements and the application deadlines on the **Official Rafik Hariri University Alumni LinkedIn page.**
3. The company name is kept confidential in most cases based on the request of employers;
4. Alumni who wish to apply to an announced job vacancy are required to send an updated CV to the Co-op and Career Services Assistant at Coop@rhu.edu.lb;
5. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant communicates with prospective employers, provides them with the CVs of the potential candidates, and follows up with them until the vacancy is generally filled.
6. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant maintains a database of all the job vacancies received, the names of the companies, major areas, and position levels (beginner, supervisory, middle management, and top management);
7. The Co-op and Career Services Assistant supplements, at the end of every academic year, a report of all the vacancies received with insights on the job market needs to help in curricular planning and selection of Summative Learning projects.